

Writing for the Web

The web page is a collection of online resources such as websites. When writing for web, using plain language allows users to find what they need, understand and use it to meet their needs. It should also be actionable, findable and shareable. The web exchanges information virtually regarding text, photograph, audio, video, program, mail message etc. For writing a web page, we need to have certain amount of knowledge about how to make information available on Internet via different Web browsers. All we need is an account on a machine where a Web server is running and some introduction to a simple markup language called HTML.

Getting Started on Web Pages:

Before we start writing for the web, we need to install or have basic software such as notepad, VScode, Sublime etc. necessary for the Web page design. Then we need to plan about what our website look like. We need to have basic knowledge of HTML, CSS and JS. Once we have finished writing the code and organizing files that make up our website, we need to publish it so that it goes online and people can find it.

Reading Web Pages: Because of the interactive nature of the Internet, with pages that respond to user input, users read online material differently from the way they read printed text. Where people read books and magazines in a linear fashion from one page to next, web readers scan pages from the top center, then down from left to right, looking for keywords. Instead of turning pages, readers follow links, jumping from one page to another and one site to another, wherever their interests take them. Online readers want speed and convenience.

Planning Web Pages: To write text for the web, we need to think through the basics of planning a document: What is the purpose? Who is the audience? Our challenge is to achieve our purpose and meet the needs of our audience.

⊗. Organizing and Designing Web Pages:

Organizing Web Pages: To begin organizing web pages, use sticky notes or index cards to list everything that we want to include - no more than one item per note or card. Group items into similar categories, considering the importance of each idea to our users. Place notes on a white board or bulletin board so we can move them around until we have an outline that works with topics and subtopics. Common ways to organize information on a website are by category, task, product, date/time, or department.

Once we have an outline, we can decide how to structure our website. A simple site may move forward in a linear fashion from one page to the next, similar to a flowchart. Other sites organize pages in a hierarchy, similar to an organizational chart. We will need a plan for a system of hyperlinks. Hyperlinks, also called links, are a word, phrase, or graphic used to link, or join, pages within a site or to an external site, allowing viewers to move easily from page to page.

Designing Web Pages: Following principles should be used when designing Web pages or website:

- 1) Header: Create a header, the banner spanning the top of a web page, to set the appropriate image and tone for our site. For example a site advertising sports cars, on the other hand, might use a bright colors, a photo of a red Corvette, and a bold font to evoke excitement.
- 2) Page layout: To help readers scan for relevant information, organize information under relevant headings. If our page is too long, divide the information into multiple shorter pages with corresponding links to those pages. Do not set up pages so visitors have to scroll horizontally.

3) Line length: A shorter line length reduces eye movement needed to scan the text. The ideal line length is approximately half the width of the screen, or between 50 and 70 characters per line.

4) Graphics: Graphics break up the text, attract the reader's attention, and offer instant identification with the purpose of the website. Use graphics to provide visual relief, to support content and image, and to make the site attractive. Graphics take time to load, and too many graphics may discourage people from investigating a site.

5) Multimedia: Many pages use animation, audio and video to make a page more interesting. Although the movement and audio, may look and sound good but too much movement may annoy the reader and take long time to load.

6) Tables: Use tables to organize text and graphics. Tables give the page a uniform, clean, professional appearance. Data can go inside cells, and one table can be nested inside another.

7) Borders: Use borders around the page to draw boundaries between sections or omit borders for a more seamless look.

8) Fonts: Font sizes and styles affect screen legibility. Sans serif fonts are usually recommended for online text because they look more distinct on screen. Avoid all capital letters and boldfaced blocks of text because these styles slow down the reader.

9) Colors: Use colors to help create an inviting site. Color should reflect the site's purpose and take into account the target audience's cultural associations with color. For example, red often associated with the devil in United States, is the color of wealth and good luck in China.

10) Accessibility: It's goal is to make web content available to wide range of disabilities including visual and hearing impairments, speech and learning disabilities etc.

⊗ Writing Text for the Web:

Writing for the web is almost similar to writing text for ~~other~~ any other technical document. However, a web page is viewed on a screen, not on a sheet of paper. The screen sizes varies depending on devices so we need to apply strategies to keep our web pages organized and focused. Following things should be considered while writing text for web:

- 1) Page Title: Give each page it's own short, descriptive title - something visitors can read quickly in a browser title bar or history list.
- 2) Audience: Know target audience and write to that audience. Use simple text and try to avoid jargon unless we know reader will understand it.
- 3) Inverted Pyramid: State important points before we provide any detailed supporting information. Present the necessary information in their order of importance.
- 4) Facts, Not Hype: Keep web page as informative as possible, state the facts and avoid the hype of an overdone sales appeal. People want information if it benefits them.
- 5) Scannable Text: Our goal is to create scannable text to enable readers to locate important words and phrases, for this we should use short paragraphs and short sentences.
- 6) Headings: Use short but informative headings to help readers identify topics and decide at a glance what they want to read.
- 7) Paragraphs to Lists: Use bulleted lists to break up paragraphs, reduce the amount of text, and emphasize important content.
- 8) Keywords: To help search engines and audience to find website, in approximately the first 50 words of our text, use keywords, important words that indicate subject areas.

⊗ Special Web Pages:

1) Home Page: Home Page is the page typically encountered first on a website that usually contains links to the other pages of the site. It is also known as landing page because audience first lands on this page. We use following tips when writing text for a home page:

- Get reader's attention and announce purpose.
- Write a short introduction and conclusion.
- Consider links to short online articles.
- Include essential information.

2) Blogs: A blog is an online journal or information website displaying information in reverse chronological order, with the latest posts appearing first, at the top. It is a platform where a writer or a group of writers share their views on an individual subject. A blogger is usually an individual with special knowledge or passion about a topic and writes blog on it. In addition to text, a blog may include links and graphics. We should consider following points before posting our blog:

- Write blogs on topics you know or in which you are passionate.
- We should post regularly.
- Create a short name that is easy to remember.
- Post meaningful and accurate blogs.
- Make blog site attractive and interesting.

3) FAQ: The FAQ is an acronym for frequently Asked Question or frequently Answered Question. In FAQ website some people ask questions and some answer to asked questions. We should consider following points for FAQ:

- Determine the most frequently asked questions. What do readers ask or want to know?
- Ask question in the way so that readers will ask the question.

- Update FAQ periodically to keep the information current.
- Organize questions in order of importance or in chronological order.
- Place FAQ on website where readers can easily find it.
- Keep the answers relatively short.

4) Wikis: A wiki uses special software that allows a number of users to collaboratively author web pages, usually according to a set of guidelines. Some wikis, such as Wikipedia and BookShelfed, provide open access to anyone. Other wikis are closed, and only people granted access can contribute. Medpedia, for example is a medical wiki that allows only professionals to edit content. For Wikis we should consider following things:

- Read several articles to know how text is written and edited.
- Keep tone polite and civil even when we disagree.
- Keep the information factual.
- ~~Keep~~ Include references for information from other sources.

5) Discussion Forums: A discussion forum is a place where users can discuss items of interest or get specific questions answered. For example; on the Apple website, a discussion forum attempts to answer questions about Apple products and applications. Consider following things to interact with discussion forum:

- Read other posts to see how people generally respond.
- Provide as much information as possible when posting a concern.
- Provide accurate information when responding to a concern.
- Be concise.